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THERE WERE DIFFICULT TIMES AHEAD, both for me and for the country. But I never lost faith in my belief that the tax cuts would unleash a burst of energy that would pull us out of the recession and ignite an economic bonfire.

As I look back on those times now, I realize that the turnaround took a little longer than I expected. But I always expected it to come. I believed the economic recovery program would work because I had faith—faith in those tax cuts and faith in the American people. I felt we were going to solve our problems because we had a secret weapon in the battle: our factory workers, our farmers, our entrepreneurs, and the others among us who I believed would prove once again that the American people were gifted with and propelled by a spirit unique in the world, a spirit tenaciously devoted to solving our problems and bettering our lives, the lives of our children, and our country—and if these forces could be liberated from the restraints imposed on them by government, they'd pull the country out of its tailspin.

As I remarked at a ceremony in 1981 commemorating the two-hundredth anniversary of our victory over the British at Yorktown, "We have economic problems at home and we live in a troubled and violent world. But there is a moral fiber running through our people that makes us more than strong enough to face the tests ahead."

I was right. But it took longer than I wanted, there were a lot of things I wanted I never got, and I had some disappointments along the way.

The economic recovery program was threefold: Cut tax rates, get government regulators out of our way, and reduce